Contract vehicles & the channel

"We can't buy you" is the most common no in federal sales. Here is every common way a buyer can say yes, and how to get on it.

VEHICLE	WHAT IT IS	WHO BUYS ON IT	HOW YOU GET ON IT	SPEED
Purchase card	A government credit card for small buys	End users and labs with a card	Nothing beyond SAM registration and a quote	Weeks
GSA schedule (MAS)	GSA's main vehicle, open to almost any agency	Nearly every agency	Your own offer to GSA (months), or a reseller who holds one	Fast once on
GWACs (e.g. NASA SEWP)	Government-wide contracts for IT products and services	Any agency	Through a holder: a reseller or prime partner	Fast once on
Agency IDIQs	An agency's own multi-award contracts; orders go to holders	That agency	Win a seat when it is competed, or team with a holder	Fast for holders
BPAs	Pre-set terms for repeat buys, often off a schedule	The ordering office	Be on the underlying schedule; shape the BPA	Fast once set
OTA consortia	Prototype agreements outside the normal rules	DoD and some civilian agencies	Join the consortium; answer calls with white papers	~6 months
CSOs	Commercial solutions openings for innovative commercial tech	DoD (often DIU)	Answer the open call with a short solution brief	Months
SBIR Phase III	Sole-source follow-on to earlier SBIR/STTR work	Any agency, any money	Hold prior SBIR/STTR work on the same technology	~6 months

HOW A RESELLER SALE WORKS

The agency
A user has the problem; a program office holds the budget.

→

Contracting officer
The only person who can commit money. Orders on a vehicle.

→

Reseller / VAR
Holds the vehicle, takes the order, invoices the government.

→

You, the maker
Supply the product. You still do the selling.

WHICH PATH FITS?

Under $15,000 Purchase card. Find a user with a card and a need.

Buyer has a vehicle Order through a holder of that vehicle: sign a VAR or teaming agreement.

New tech to prove OTA prototype or CSO, with a sponsor who owns the problem.

Prior SBIR work SBIR Phase III, sole source, with any type of agency money.

Repeat demand Your own GSA schedule, once several agencies buy every year.

SIGNED VAR AGREEMENT CHECKLIST

- [ ] Signed reseller (VAR) agreement, not a handshake
- [ ] Products and pricing live on the partner's vehicle catalog
- [ ] Buyer confirmed they can see and order the items
- [ ] Reseller margin built into the government price list
- [ ] One price across every partner and vehicle
- [ ] Deal registration so partners don't compete on your deals
- [ ] TAA country of origin checked for every product
- [ ] Named contact at the partner, and a monthly pipeline review

QUESTIONS TO ASK EVERY BUYER

- Which contracts does your office buy through most?
- Who do you usually order from?
- Is there a BPA or agency IDIQ we should know about?
- Could this be a purchase card buy, or under $350,000?
- Would an OTA, CSO or SBIR Phase III fit this better?

RULES OF THUMB

- Sign at least two vehicle paths for every key buyer.
- Get your own GSA schedule only when repeat demand justifies it.
- Resellers fill orders. They rarely create demand.